

# Claude Instructions Hierarchy

Where Claude reads standing instructions from, in the app vs. in Claude Code

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## Claude.ai App

|                                   |                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1. Instructions for Claude</b> | Account-wide. Set in Settings > Profile. Applies to every new conversation, in every project.                                                                    |
| <b>2. Project instructions</b>    | Scoped to one Project's workspace. Layers on top of account-wide instructions inside that project's chats. Sits alongside the project's uploaded knowledge base. |

Two levels: global → project. Project-level instructions apply only within that project.

## Claude Code

|                             |                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1. Global CLAUDE.md</b>  | ~/ .claude/CLAUDE.md. Loads in every project alongside that project's own CLAUDE.md. Keep to preferences that apply everywhere (response style, commit format, personal conventions). |
| <b>2. Project CLAUDE.md</b> | Repo root (or .claude/CLAUDE.md). Loads automatically for that project. When it conflicts with the global file, project-level wins.                                                   |
| <b>3. Path-scoped rules</b> | .claude/rules/*.md with paths: frontmatter (globs). Load conditionally — only when Claude touches a matching file or directory, not every session.                                    |
| <b>CLAUDE.local.md</b>      | Optional, gitignored. Private per-project preferences, loaded alongside CLAUDE.md but not committed to the repo.                                                                      |

Three levels: global → project → path-scoped rules. Rules are the one tier the app doesn't have — they let instructions load only when relevant to the file being worked on, instead of every session.

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**Both systems always load and combine the applicable files** — they are not mutually exclusive overrides. In Claude Code, global and project CLAUDE.md content are both placed in context together (project wins on direct conflicts); rules are added on top only when their path pattern matches.

Sources: Claude Help Center — "What are projects?" and "Styles are moving to skills" ([support.claude.com](https://support.claude.com)) · Claude Code docs — "Explore the .claude directory" ([code.claude.com/docs](https://code.claude.com/docs))